

Post-incident review PIR-2025-041

Search Service: elevated error rates

Contoso Platform Engineering. Fictional sample data.

Summary

On 13 May 2025, Search Service experienced elevated error rates in production (AU East) for about 40 minutes. A scripted sign-in probe started failing from two regions. Investigation found that a null reference in the new release crashed workers on a rare input.

Impact

Users of Search Service saw elevated error rates for about 40 minutes. The service owner, Digital Channels, led the response.

Timeline

- 09:03 First signal received.
- 09:39 Incident declared and on-call team engaged.
- 09:51 Likely cause identified.
- 10:30 Mitigation applied.
- 10:53 Service confirmed healthy and incident closed.

What happened

Investigation found that a null reference in the new release crashed workers on a rare input.

Certificates were checked as part of triage and were valid.

All traffic depended on one component with no standby.

What went well

Responders communicated clearly in the incident channel and the status page was updated within fifteen minutes of the incident being declared.

Actions

- Load test the service at twice the expected peak before the next campaign.
- Write and rehearse a runbook for this failure mode.
- Exercise the rollback path in staging as part of every release.